

Air and Angels



POEM TEXT

1 Twice or thrice had I lov'd thee,
2 Before I knew thy face or name;
3 So in a voice, so in a shapeless flame
4 Angels affect us oft, and worshipp'd be;
5 Still when, to where thou wert, I came,
6 Some lovely glorious nothing I did see.
7 But since my soul, whose child love is,
8 Takes limbs of flesh, and else could nothing do,
9 More subtle than the parent is
10 Love must not be, but take a body too;
11 And therefore what thou wert, and who,
12 I bid Love ask, and now
13 That it assume thy body, I allow,
14 And fix itself in thy lip, eye, and brow.

15 Whilst thus to ballast love I thought,
16 And so more steadily to have gone,
17 With wares which would sink admiration,
18 I saw I had love's pinnacle overfraught;
19 Ev'ry thy hair for love to work upon
20 Is much too much, some fitter must be sought;
21 For, nor in nothing, nor in things
22 Extreme, and scatt'ring bright, can love inhere;
23 Then, as an angel, face, and wings
24 Of air, not pure as it, yet pure, doth wear,
25 So thy love may be my love's sphere;
26 Just such disparity
27 As is 'twixt air and angels' purity,
28 'Twixt women's love, and men's, will ever be.

your eyes, your forehead.

I thought that, once my love was embodied in you, it would travel along more steadily, like a loaded and well-balanced ship, carrying glorious goods that would sink the metaphorical ship of a mere crush. But then, I understood that I had loaded love's boat too heavily. Even a single hair of yours is too overwhelming for love to work on; I need some more fitting vessel for my love. For love can't live in nothing, but it also can't live in something so extraordinarily, gloriously bright as your hair. When angels take on bodies, they make them out of air, which (though it isn't as pure as the angels themselves) is still pure. In that case, rather than taking on your body, my love must embody itself in *your* love. The difference between the purity of air and the purity of an angel is just the same as the difference between the purity of women's love and the purity of men's love, and always will be.



THEMES



SPIRITUAL AND PHYSICAL LOVE

"Air and Angels" explores the spiritual and physical dimensions of love. The poem's speaker argues that, just as a soul can't do anything unless it has a body, love can't act without some kind of physical form. In this way, the speaker suggests, love is like an angel. According to Renaissance theology, angels are beings of pure thought; they appear to people by taking on bodies made of air. The speaker concludes that the immaterial ideal of Love must therefore act similarly: it must become *embodied* in order to enter the world.

At first, the speaker believes that his love has come to life on earth by manifesting in his *beloved's* body, taking shape in her "lip, eye, and brow." She, in other words, strikes him as the glorious embodiment of Love itself. But he ultimately decides that this idea doesn't quite work. Love, as something ideal and divine, can't live purely in the physical world any more than it can live in "nothing."

Here he turns again to the idea of how angels work and suggests that, rather than his beloved's *body*, his love might take its shape through his beloved's *love* for him. Just as an angel takes on a body of air—imagined as the purest and most refined element in Donne's day—the speaker's love will take on a body made of his beloved's *feelings* for him. Their two loves have to come together in order to exist in the world; one can't exist without the other.

Besides expressing a complex philosophical idea, this is the speaker's way of celebrating the fact that his beloved loves him back. And the speaker's vision of his beloved's feelings



SUMMARY

Before I ever knew you, I'd already loved you two or three times. We meet angels in just the same way; they appear to us as a voice, or as a wavering tongue of fire, and we worship them. Likewise, when I met you, what I saw at first was some gorgeous, immaterial thing. But my soul (the parent of Love) has a body—if it weren't, it couldn't do anything, after all. And since Love is my soul's child, it can't be *less* material than my soul; it needs a body, as well. I thus asked Love to reveal to me who you were and what your background was. Now, I believe, Love has taken shape in your body, affixing itself to your lips,

physically encompassing his, becoming their "sphere," also suggests that *sexual* connection might also be involved in wholehearted love!

In this poem, the speaker's love involves the intersection of two different components, a connection that produces something new. Love lands right between the physical and the spiritual, neither purely bodily nor purely intellectual.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-28



WOMEN'S LOVE VS. MEN'S LOVE

In "Air and Angels," women and men must rely on each other to bring love into the world. In a complex [conceit](#), the poem's speaker imagines his love as something like an angel—in Renaissance theology, a being of pure thought that had to take on a body of air in order to appear to human beings and act on earth. If his love is going to live, the speaker realizes, then it will need to take some kind of body too. And while he at first imagines that his beloved's *body* is the right medium to give his love shape, he at last decides that it's "much too much" to ask that love should take on human flesh, no matter how beautiful that flesh might be. Instead, he concludes that his beloved's *feelings* for him can be the "air" to the "angel" of his feelings for her. Rather ungallantly, then, he appears to conclude that love can come into the world precisely because there's a "disparity" between the "purity" of love that women and men feel for each other. His love, in this vision, is something as pure as an angel, while his beloved's love is merely as pure as air: something very refined and ethereal, but physical nonetheless.

That "disparity" isn't a problem, though. In fact, it's *necessary* if love is going to exist. The difference between the love that women and men feel, the speaker suggests, is necessary if love is going to come into the world. Women and men rely on each other to give love shape and life. A very simple way of approaching this idea might be: love in the abstract is a beautiful *idea*, but it's not exactly full-fledged love unless it can come to life *between* two different people.

While this vision draws on some rather misogynistic Renaissance ideas about women as more fleshly and men as more spiritual, it also cuts against the grain of those ideas by suggesting that women and men aren't locked in some terrible battle of the sexes, tormenting each other by their difference. Far from it: they depend on each other to bring an angelic, divinely beautiful love to life on earth. And if women's love isn't as pure as men's, it's still pretty darn pure!

Readers should also note that there's a whole lot of critical debate about whether the speaker is saying that men's love is purer than women's, that women's love is purer than men's, or

([paradoxically](#)) both at once! While the former reading is the most obvious, it's far from the only possible interpretation here. What really matters in "Air and Angels" is not which of the parties in a heterosexual romance has the more or less refined flavor of love. It's that love comes from a meeting of *differences*, a merging in which two separate people's loves bring each other to life.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 21-28



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*Twice or thrice had I lov'd thee,
Before I knew thy face or name;
So in a voice, so in a shapeless flame
Angels affect us oft, and worshipp'd be;
Still when, to where thou wert, I came,
Some lovely glorious nothing I did see.*

"Air and Angels" is a passionate love poem—and one of metaphysical poet John Donne's trickiest, shiftiest works. Its complexities unfold from its very first lines. As the poem begins, the speaker, a lover, appears to be paying his beloved a tremendous compliment. But he might also be trying to excuse his own past romantic dalliances. For that matter, he might be doing both of these things at once!

He begins by telling his beloved that he had already loved her "twice or thrice" before he even knew her "face or name." This is possible, he says, because that's how angels work: they appear from time to time in a "voice" or a "shapeless flame," calling out to people or dazzling them without fully revealing themselves. They appear and they "affect us," the speaker says—language that means two things at once:

- Angels "affect" people in that they have an effect on them, certainly.
- But they also "affect" people in the sense of "have affection for": angels put in their benevolent appearances on earth in order to share divine love.

The speaker, then, is telling his beloved she's nothing less than an angel, a being of heavenly intensity. Readers here might want to think about what that would mean to a Renaissance Christian theologian like Donne (who served as an important Protestant clergyman in 17th-century London):

- A Renaissance-era angel wouldn't be a winged lady in a white robe twanging on a harp, but a dazzling, brilliant force, a herald of God.

- The [imagery](#) of that “shapeless flame” gets at how awe-inspiring a visitation from such an angel might feel: the flame’s shapelessness conjures up an ever-shifting billow of fire, something ungraspable, powerful, bright, and dangerous.

If the speaker has already met his beloved “twice or thrice” as one might have first contact with an angel, then, he’s had some “shapeless,” mighty-but-elusive glimpse of his love for her before. In other words, he’s perhaps *imagined* what it might be like to love somebody like he loves her, or he’s had some hint of what his heart is capable of. But never until she came into his life did he experience the full force of love—a force, he suggests, that’s past full human comprehension. At the beloved’s first appearance to the speaker, she struck him as “some lovely glorious nothing,” a [paradoxical](#) image that suggests her loveliness was so transcendent it was beyond him, perhaps even beyond this world. He loved her so much he felt he was seeing something unreal.

This is a deeply passionate image of romantic love bringing heaven to earth. But there’s a twist in its tail. When the speaker says that he felt he’d encountered his beloved “twice or thrice” before he knew her, he might also be making an excuse for having been with two or three other ladies before she turned up! In this reading, those other women were heralds of his *true* beloved; he caught a glimpse of her beauty in their mere prettiness, maybe, or a hint of his feelings for her in a brief moment of passion. Certainly this is still a compliment, but one that vibrates at a very different pitch.

Both of these possibilities, the more divine and the earthier, are present at the same time—and that is all part of what makes this poem as dizzying and dazzling as it is. “Air and Angels” will go on to contemplate the relationship of heavenly and earthly love through a series of double meanings and elusive [metaphors](#), attempting to represent a love so great that—like a “shapeless flame”—it just can’t be grasped.

LINES 7-14

*But since my soul, whose child love is,
Takes limbs of flesh, and else could nothing do,
More subtle than the parent is
Love must not be, but take a body too;
And therefore what thou wert, and who,
I bid Love ask, and now
That it assume thy body, I allow,
And fix itself in thy lip, eye, and brow.*

The speaker began the poem with the claim that his beloved is the very angel of love—so much so that when he first saw her, he thought she might not even be an earthly being, but “some lovely glorious nothing.”

But there’s a problem with that idea. Love, the speaker [metaphorically](#) reasons, is the “child” of his soul: it’s born from

the spirit. And in order to exist in the world, his soul has to “take[] limbs of flesh.” In other words, the soul has to be *embodied*, or else it “could nothing do”—it would be helpless. The soul needs a body to get around, to act, to *exist* in the world. And if the soul is love’s “parent,” then *love* must need a body, too. Embodied souls can’t give birth to bodiless spirits; the child can’t be “more subtle,” more rarified and ethereal, than its parent.

The speaker, then, couldn’t possibly just love the *idea* or the *ideal* of love, the glimpses of love he’d had “twice or thrice” in the past. His love needed somehow to be embodied in the world if it were to truly live.

All of a sudden, the speaker’s love becomes a separate, [personified](#) force—an energy searching for a way to express itself. The speaker tells his beloved that he “bid Love ask” who she was and where he might find her; that is, he appealed to the spirit of Love itself, telling it to go and find the lady who could give it a body. The only possible answer was this one woman, the ideal beloved. Now, the speaker says, his love has found itself a body by taking on *hers*, “assum[ing]” her gorgeous form and “fix[ing]” itself securely in her “lip, eye, and brow.” Her face has become Love’s face; in two senses, she *is* the speaker’s love.

Love here skips in and out of different forms. Personified, Love is something that belongs to the speaker, the “child” of his soul; it’s a separate and independent creature, a force the speaker can appeal to; finally, it’s the beloved herself, an outside figure who *appeared* to the speaker like a “lovely glorious” vision of perfection, better than he could even have hoped. Love works as a go-between here, connecting and partly *merging* two separate people—much as an angel works as a messenger from the heavens to the earth.

Here at the end of the first stanza, readers might consider how the *poem* embodies love. Each of this poem’s stanzas uses 14 lines, nodding to the traditional shape of a [sonnet](#)—a form often concerned with matters of romance. Their meter, however, is irregular:

- A typical sonnet uses steady [iambic](#) pentameter (that is, lines of five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in “Some love- | ly glor- | ious noth- | ing I | did see”).
- This poem’s stanzas, by contrast, mostly move back and forth between iambic tetrameter (lines of four iambs, as in line 2’s “Before | I knew | thy face | or name”) and iambic pentameter, dipping down to a single dramatic moment of iambic trimeter (three iambs) in each stanza’s twelfth line (as in line 12’s “I bid | Love ask, | and now”).

Alongside Donne’s twisty phrasing, this pulsing, unpredictable rhythm asks readers to stay on their toes, applying their intellects as well as their feelings to the problems this poem

presents.

LINES 15-20

*Whilst thus to ballast love I thought,
And so more steadily to have gone,
With wares which would sink admiration,
I saw I had love's pinnacle overfraught;
Ev'ry thy hair for love to work upon
Is much too much, some fitter must be sought;*

In the first stanza, the speaker concluded that his beloved embodies Love itself. Her body is love's body; she gives love a shape and the ability to live in the world. As the second stanza begins, however, the speaker undercuts that heightened, dreamlike praise with complex reasoning. He *thought* that his angelic beloved could embody his love, he says—but on reflection, that idea doesn't quite work.

He explains why in a crafty [conceit](#). By sending Love to embody itself in his beloved, he says, he thought that he could “ballast” it, weighing it down and keeping it “stead[y]”—a [metaphor](#) that makes love into a merchant ship loaded with glorious “wares,” or goods. (So many “wares,” in fact, that they’d “sink admiration”—that they’d sink the lesser ship of a mere infatuation, sending it straight to the bottom of the metaphorical sea.) But just when he thought he’d got it all worked out, he says, he “saw [he] had love’s pinnacle overfraught.” In other words, he’d overloaded love’s “pinnacle,” its little ship. He’d put too much *weight* on it.

There’s something very tricky going on here, and this vivid metaphor is, in essence, rather unclear. Is the beloved’s *body* the ship, overloaded with love? Or is *love* the ship, overloaded with the weight of a beautiful human body?

Nothing becomes any clearer when the speaker explains:

*Ev'ry thy hair for love to work upon
Is much too much, some fitter must be sought;*

Certainly, there’s an image of *excess* here. The speaker is saying that it’s “much too much” to expect that love could inhabit every single one of the beloved’s hairs. (Even that [diacope](#) on “much too much” suggests total overwhelm.) If the beloved’s actual physical *body* were the embodiment of love, in other words, *something* simply couldn't float. The speaker needs to find “some fitter” (some more fitting) way to embody love than his beloved’s body.

Perhaps the most straightforward reading here is that the speaker sees the divine force of love as too heavy for the body to carry. That reading gets likelier when readers consider the bodily [pun](#) on “love’s *pinnacle*.” The fleshy body gets overwhelmed if it’s made to carry the full weight of love—the speaker’s body as much as the beloved’s!

But another (rather [hyperbolically](#) complimentary) reading is

also possible and present here. The speaker hints that the beloved’s sheer physical beauty has the power to overwhelm even divine, ideal love: that the gorgeousness of each and every hair on her head is “much too much,” there would be no way for him to *manage* his love if it took the form of her physical body.

What the speaker really needs, then, is a different *medium* through which to bring his love to life in the world—and, as the next lines will suggest, “medium” really is the right word. The speaker needs to find something *between* the physical and the spiritual.

LINES 21-25

*For, nor in nothing, nor in things
Extreme, and scatt'ring bright, can love inhere;
Then, as an angel, face, and wings
Of air, not pure as it, yet pure, doth wear,
So thy love may be my love's sphere;*

In these lines, the speaker comes to the crux of the poem, its intellectual and [metaphorical](#) heart. While he once believed that his beloved’s body had become Love itself, he now concludes that:

[...] nor in nothing, nor in things
Extreme, and scatt'ring bright, can love inhere;

In other words, if love can’t exist *without* a body as “some lovely glorious nothing,” it also can’t exist in *physical* bodies. Again, there’s an intense compliment here: the speaker imagines the beloved’s body as something “extreme, and scatt’ring bright,” [imagery](#) that suggests her beauty is dazzling and reflective, sending showers of brilliance flying around her, like light bouncing off water or a faceted crystal. (Perhaps the more specific image here is of her shining hair, as raised in the line in which “ev’ry thy hair” is “much too much” for love to inhabit.)

Here, the speaker suggests that love can’t “inhere” (that is, become spiritually manifest in) things at either extreme. It can’t exist as a “nothing,” an absence of form; it can’t exist in the solid physical world. (Characteristically, Donne isn’t suggesting that the physical body is too lowly and material for love here, but that it’s too overwhelmingly beautiful!)

This brings the poem to its central [conceit](#), the complex [extended metaphor](#) introduced in its title. Love, the speaker concludes, needs to find some *medium*, a substance in between *nothing* and a physical *something*, in order to enter the world. In this, it’s like an angel as conceived of in Renaissance theology:

- To Donne and his contemporaries, an angel was a being of pure thought, a kind of divine idea. If an angel wanted to appear to the mortal, fleshly eyes of a human being, it had to make itself a body.
- And if it wanted to make itself a body, it would build it from air—then considered the purest and most

refined of the four traditional elements (earth, air, fire, and water) and thus the most suitable substance for a being of thought to take form through. Air is “not pure as” an angel, but it’s still pretty darn pure!

The speaker thus discovers the answer to his riddle. The angelic beloved’s *body*, the speaker concludes, isn’t the right medium to give form to the speaker’s love. Her *love* is. In this image, the beloved’s feelings for the speaker become his feelings’ “sphere,” the body that encompasses and gives form to his love.

There’s a sexual undertone to this idea as well. The beloved’s love *envelops* the speaker’s to give it form. The union of two different loves here produces a new metaphorical “body,” just as the union of two different physical bodies might produce the new body and soul of a child.

Once again, though, these lines are far from straightforward. Critics have debated for years over lines 9–10, in which the word “it” might just as easily refer to the angel and the air; there are reasonable arguments on either side about what’s being described as the “purest” medium, here (many of them based on points of Renaissance theology too complex and obscure to treat here). What’s certain is that love, in this vision, manifests in the union of two subtly different things. Love in the abstract is a “lovely glorious nothing,” a dream and an ideal—but it can’t fully come to life without meeting its match. The speaker’s love meets the beloved’s love, and thus a living Love comes into the world. This is a mysterious and dazzling celebration of requited passion.

LINES 26–28

*Just such disparity
As is 'twixt air and angels' purity,
'Twixt women's love, and men's, will ever be.*

After the poem’s exalted praise of the beloved and of love itself, the final lines might come as a surprise: at first glance, they bring the poem down to earth with a bump. The speaker has pictured the beloved as an angel and as a being “extreme, and scatt’ring bright,” an otherworldly force of beauty and love. Now, he concludes with words that strike many readers as far from gallant:

*Just such disparity
As is 'twixt air and angels' purity,
'Twixt women's love, and men's, will ever be.*

In other words: there’s a difference between the purity of air and angels, and there’s a difference between the purity of men’s love and women’s love, and that will always, always be true.

At first sight, this might feel like an abrupt turn to misogynistic

Renaissance ideas about the difference between men and women. Perhaps surprisingly to modern-day readers, women were once imagined as the more fleshly, lustful, and earthy of the sexes, while men were said to be the more spiritual and pure-hearted in love. While there was [plenty of contemporary debate](#) about those ideas, that would roughly be the cultural assumption. Here it would seem to make a certain sense. If the beloved’s love is less pure than the speaker’s, then it can form the medium for his love to take shape, just as less-pure air gives a pure angel its form.

In one sense, these lines might *redeem* the idea of such a difference between the sexes. Rather than suggesting that women are heartless deceivers who only want one thing from men (and he [wasn’t above doing so!](#)), Donne here seems to suggest that the qualitative difference between men’s and women’s loves is *necessary* in order for love to exist in the world—in much the same way that, say, you need both a sperm and an egg in order to make an embryo. For that matter, the beloved’s love isn’t imagined as something *impure* here, only just a tiny bit less pure than the “angel” of the speaker’s love.

For that matter, the poem’s tricky, ambiguous language means that it’s not even totally clear that this is what the speaker is claiming! These lines can also be read to mean that *men’s* love is the less pure (a question resting on what the word “it” signifies in line 9, as explored above). And indeed, that potential ambiguity might leave readers hanging in a [paradox](#), knowing only this: what matters in bringing love about is that two differences embrace each other and create something new in the middle.

By dancing between the idealistic and the cynical, the sublime and the earthy, this poem is a portrait of love in more ways than one. Its breathtaking angelic visions never leave out the possibility of dirty jokes, worries, disappointments, and doubts—and perhaps this dance between extremes captures better than anything what it’s like to be profoundly in love.



POETIC DEVICES

CONCEIT

The poem’s central [conceit](#) (or elaborate [extended metaphor](#)) draws on an esoteric point of Renaissance theology. In the Christian belief of Donne’s era, angels were said to be creatures of pure thought: living divine ideas. In order to serve their role as God’s messengers and appear to human beings—lower, fleshier creatures—angels had to build themselves bodies of air (considered the purest of the four traditional elements in Donne’s day, more refined than fire, water, or earth). As a material thing, air could never be as exalted and pure as an angel is, but it would be the best of the available options! Both of the speaker’s major arguments to his beloved rest on this idea.

In the first stanza, the speaker suggests to his beloved that she has appeared to him “twice or thrice” before he met her—just in a different form. Readers might interpret this statement in one of a couple of (contradictory!) ways:

- He’s had two or three lovers before her, but he knows that they were just imperfect manifestations of the love she finally revealed to him in its most perfect form. In that sense, these earlier lovers were the “air” to the “angel” that is his beloved.
- He’s had imaginative glimpses of a love as perfect as the one he felt for her before, but never found it manifested in this world until she appeared and embodied perfect love for him. In this sense, the *beloved* is the “air” to the “angel” of pure love.

Either way, the speaker realizes that this idea won’t quite do. In the second stanza, he observes that love can’t “inhere” (that is, become spiritually manifest) either in “nothing”—for it needs a body to work through—or in mortal flesh like his beloved’s. The only “air” that can embody the “angel” of love fittingly is the beloved’s love for the speaker.

Where Conceit appears in the poem:

- Lines 3-14
- Lines 21-28

METAPHOR

One elaborate, dizzying [extended metaphor](#) isn’t enough for any John Donne poem. Alongside his central [conceit](#) of angels and air, Donne also uses the [metaphors](#) of the child and the boat to express the difficulty and necessity of giving love form.

In introducing the idea that immaterial things like love and angels need to take on bodies to act in the world, the speaker uses the following metaphor:

But since my soul, whose child love is,
Takes limbs of flesh, and else could nothing do,
More subtle than the parent is
Love must not be, but take a body too;

In other words: love here is the metaphorical “child” of the soul, and the soul is therefore love’s “parent.” The soul needs to inhabit a body in order to act in the world—and if love is the soul’s child, it can’t be more “subtle,” more ethereal and immaterial, than its “parent” is. A fleshly creature can’t give birth to a creature of pure spirit, in other words!

As the speaker thinks further about the problem of giving love form, he realizes that love can’t simply embody itself in his beloved’s flesh, no matter how glorious she is. He uses a new extended metaphor to explore the difficulty here:

Whilst thus to ballast love I thought,
And so more steadily to have gone,
With wares which would sink admiration,
I saw I had love’s pinnace overfraught;

In this image, love is a “pinnace,” a little ship—and in trying to “ballast” (or weight and balance) that ship with the earthly “wares” of his beloved’s body, the speaker realizes he’s loaded it up too much. The body *alone*, in other words, can’t be tasked with manifesting love on earth.

But there’s something tricky going on here. This image of *love* as a ship overloaded with the *body*’s wares might also present the *body* as a ship overloaded with *love*’s wares. “Love’s pinnace,” in other words, could also mean the body that tries to *carry* love and finds itself overloaded. (The sneaky, naughty [pun](#) on “pinnace” here similarly hints that the pinnace could be something fleshly!) Perhaps it’s impossible for the body to manifest love because the body is mortal and frail (however lovely) and love is “much too much” for it to carry; perhaps it’s impossible for love to manifest in the speaker’s beloved because her beauty is “much too much” for love to take on.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-10:** “ But since my soul, whose child love is, / Takes limbs of flesh, and else could nothing do, / More subtle than the parent is / Love must not be, but take a body too;”
- **Lines 15-18:** “Whilst thus to ballast love I thought, / And so more steadily to have gone, / With wares which would sink admiration, / I saw I had love’s pinnace overfraught;”

IMAGERY

The [imagery](#) of “Air and Angels” burns and dazzles like the ethereal angels of the speaker’s imagination.

When he describes the ways in which angels might first appear to people, for instance, the speaker pictures being visited by a spirit in the form of a “shapeless flame”—an image that captures something uncapturable. The shapelessness of this imagined flame suggests, not the steady little teardrop of a lit candle, but the constant movement of a hovering, billowing fire. This flame’s shapelessness reminds readers that the speaker is talking about something that’s *intangible* but also *powerful*. You can’t hold onto a fire, but it can certainly “affect” you, as an angel might!

The body of the speaker’s beloved is also, to him, angelically brilliant. Her hair, he says, is something “extreme, and scatt’ring bright.” That “scatt’ring” brightness might make readers picture the way that the sun bounces off a faceted crystal or the surface of a pond: this image, too, is of scintillating, ever-moving light. Readers might imagine heavy showers of dazzle flinging out from the beloved’s hair as she turns her head.

In both of these images, the speaker envisions angelic beauty and love as things that gleam and move. This sort of glorious force evades the grasp of the hand and the mind alike.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** “so in a shapeless flame”
- **Lines 21-22:** “things / Extreme, and scatt'ring bright”

REPETITION

[Repetition](#) fills “Air and Angels” with music while also emphasizing important images and ideas. When the speaker describes how his beloved appeared to him before he even knew her, for instance, he tells her that in this she’s very like an angel. For angels also appear in mysterious forms before revealing themselves:

So in a voice, so in a shapeless flame
Angels affect us oft, and worshipp'd be;

The [anaphora](#) of “so” there makes the speaker sound like a magician, casually summoning up these images of angel visitations—a voice, a billow of fire. The repeated “so” also just *sounds* good, seductively (and sibilantly) silky, just the right effect for wooing one’s angelic beloved.

A later repetition captures the speaker’s overwhelm at the idea that love might take on his beloved’s body:

Ev'ry thy hair for love to work upon
Is much too much, [...]

The [diacope](#) on “much” there evokes what seems like near-panic as the speaker contemplates *every single hair* of a mortal body overwhelmed by the spiritual might of perfect love.

That thought leads him to a [paradox](#):

For, nor in nothing, nor in things
Extreme, and scatt'ring bright, can love inhere;

The anaphora of “nor” gets at the problem here: love can’t embody itself in “nothing,” but it can’t embody itself in physical “things” either (no matter how gorgeously “extreme, and scatt’ring bright” those things might be).

A final repetition creates a mirror in the poem’s closing lines:

Just such disparity
As is 'twixt air and angels' purity,
'Twixt women's love, and men's, will ever be.

The [parallelism](#) here sets up an analogy—but an elusive one. Certainly, the speaker is making the point that there’s a difference between the purity of men’s and women’s love and

that this contrast parallels the difference between the purity of air and the purity of angels. On the surface, the speaker appears to be saying that women’s less-pure love forms the “sphere,” the embodiment, for men’s purer love. But earlier ambiguities in the poem make that not so very clear as these lines appear quoted out of context. (For instance, there’s a question about whether the word “it” in line 24—“Of air, not pure as it, yet pure, doth wear”—refers to the angel or the air!) The neatly matched language here is a tease.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** “So in a voice, so in a shapeless flame”
- **Line 20:** “much too much”
- **Line 27:** “'twixt”
- **Line 28:** “'Twixt”

PERSONIFICATION

By [personifying](#) “Love” itself, the speaker presents it as a force at once *connected* to him and *independent* from him, a being with its own opinions, intentions, and designs.

In line 7, the speaker imagines his love as the child of his soul. In this [metaphor](#), his love is in some sense under his care, born from his own inner self. But that idea gets a lot more complicated when the speaker imagines that his love needs to somehow be embodied if it’s really going to come to life. Then, he begins to address love more as if it were a god—or, indeed, a matchmaker. The speaker asks Love to seek out the woman who can give it form; Love locates the speaker’s beloved, and then *becomes* the speaker’s beloved, “fix[ing] itself” in her “lip, eye, and brow.” (Or so the speaker at first believes, before concluding that love can’t really “inhere”—or become spiritually manifest—in a physical body.)

This complex, metamorphosing personification suggests that love is many things at once. It belongs to the speaker and it doesn’t; it lives in the speaker’s beloved and grows independently of her. Love, in this vision, is independent as a separate person—but it’s also a force that moves between and joins different people.

Where Personification appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-14:** “ But since my soul, whose child love is, / Takes limbs of flesh, and else could nothing do, / More subtle than the parent is / Love must not be, but take a body too; / And therefore what thou wert, and who, / I bid Love ask, and now / That it assume thy body, I allow, / And fix itself in thy lip, eye, and brow.”



VOCABULARY

Thee, Thou, Thy (Line 1, Line 2, Line 5, Line 11, Line 19, Line 25) - Old-fashioned ways of saying "you" and "your":

- "Thee" is the object form of "you," as in "I love thee"
- "Thou" is the subject form of you, as in "Thou art my beloved"
- "Thy" means "your"

Affect (Line 4) - Here, "affect" can mean both "have an influence over" and "feel affection for."

Wert (Line 5, Line 11) - An old-fashioned way of saying "were."

Else could nothing do (Line 8) - In other words, "couldn't do anything otherwise." The speaker is saying that his soul needs to be embodied if it's going to be able to act!

Subtle (Line 9) - Ethereal, immaterial.

Bid (Line 12) - Told, asked.

Assume (Line 13) - Take on, wear. The idea is that Love itself has taken the form of the speaker's beloved; her body becomes Love's garment.

Fix (Line 14) - Attach, root itself, settle into place.

Ballast (Line 15) - Weigh down in order to keep something fixed or steady. (For instance, a ship uses ballast to stay level in the water.)

Pinnacle (Line 18) - A small ship (also, a likely [pun](#) on male genitalia).

Overfraught (Line 18) - Loaded with too much freight (or goods). The [metaphor](#) is taken from a ship filled up with too many wares.

Scatt'ring bright (Line 22) - "Scatt'ring" just means "scattering." The lovely image here is of something so brilliantly glittering and reflective that it scatters fragments of light all around it.

Then, as an angel, face, and wings / Of air, not pure as it, yet pure, doth wear (Lines 23-24) - The [allusion](#) here is to an old theological idea that angels' visible forms were made of air, but that angels themselves were beings of pure thought; they put on airy bodies to appear to humans.

Sphere (Line 25) - Here, the orbit of a planet. The planets were once imagined to be held in place by crystalline spheres that rotated through the heavens.

Disparity (Line 26) - Difference, mismatch.

'Twixt (Line 27, Line 28) - Between.

they hint at the [sonnet](#) form, calling up a kind of poem often used to discuss matters of love. But Donne picks up the sonnet shape only to turn it topsy-turvy. Besides the strange, irregular [rhyme scheme](#) and meter here, these stanzas resemble Italian sonnets turned upside down:

- An Italian sonnet begins with an octave (an eight-line passage, in which the speaker introduces a problem or a question) and ends in a sestet (a six-line passage, in which the speaker resolves that question, often in a surprising way).
- The stanzas in this poem, by contrast, open with sestets and close with octaves—and they raise more questions than they answer!

The unexpected complexity of this poem's form matches the complexity of the speaker's thought. Heaping [metaphor](#) on metaphor, calling up the traditional sonnet form and then turning it on its head, the speaker attempts to capture love: a force too airy and pure for this world. Just as the speaker does his best to figure out how his love can take shape on earth, this poem does its best to embody dizzying thought in an unpredictable and elusive shape.

METER

Like many of Donne's poems, "Air and Angels" plays complex games with [meter](#). The poem is mostly [iambic](#)—that is, written in iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "Before"—but dances between lines of trimeter (three feet in a row), tetrameter (four feet), and pentameter (five feet). Lines 11-13 provide a sample of each:

And there- | fore what | thou wert, | and who,
I bid | Love ask, | and now
That it | assume | thy bod- | y, I | allow,

The pattern in which Donne deploys these changing rhythms is a little different in each stanza. He often breaks from the soothing pulse of pentameter, too—even in his very first line, which runs like this:

Twice or thrice had I lov'd thee,

These complex rhythms carry complex thoughts! Rather than sinking into an easy, gentle, predictable meter, Donne here asks his readers to stay on their toes. The dodge and weave of the poem's meter suits the speaker's ethereal, intricate [conceit](#).

RHYME SCHEME

The strange, weaving [rhyme scheme](#) of "Air and Angels" runs as follows:

ABBABACDCDDEEE

This pattern is deceptive in that it might at first trick the reader



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Air and Angels" is divided into two 14-line stanzas. Those 14 lines might ring a bell for readers familiar with English poetry:

into expecting one of the traditional rhyme schemes of a [sonnet](#): alongside the 14-line stanzas here (each of which is the length of a sonnet), the ABBA with which the poem begins might suggest the start of an Italian sonnet (a kind of poem whose rhyme scheme always begins ABBA ABBA). But the speaker soon dances out of the way of that pattern, teasing readers of this notoriously complex poem: *Keep up!*

Note that, while some of the rhymes here might sound [slant](#) to a modern-day reader's ear (like "wear" and "sphere" in lines 24-25), many were likely perfect in Donne's 17th-century London accent.



SPEAKER

This poem's speaker is a lover who seems to unite extreme and disparate qualities: he might be exalted or jaded, idealistic or cynical, or all these things at once. It's almost impossible to pin this guy down. His love poem may argue that women's love is less pure than men's, that men's love is less pure than women's, that women and men purify each other's imperfect love—or, mysteriously and [paradoxically](#), all these things at once!

In one reading, this poem's speaker is so profoundly in love that he at first feels his beloved might be the very *embodiment* of Love. But he at last comes to the conclusion that love can't "inhere" in (or spiritually imbue) a lovely mortal body like his beloved's, which is simply "much too much" for love to "work upon." Just as an angel (a being of pure thought) has to build itself a body of air (the purest and most rarified of the traditional four elements), his love needs to make itself a body of something *almost*, but not *quite*, as pure as itself.

The speaker decides at last that this substance is his *lady's* love for *him*—for women's love, he appears to conclude, must always be just that little bit less pure than men's. Here, the speaker seems to be drawing on an old Renaissance trope (or anxiety) that women's love was weaker and more changeable than men's—a point that Donne memorably groused over in "[Go and catch a falling star](#)" and Shakespeare's Viola and Orsino [debate in Twelfth Night](#).

But this is only *one* reading of the speaker's closing lines—and one that seems rather out of tune with the rest of the poem, in which the speaker suggests that his beloved is an angel come to earth! This notoriously complex poem can also be read to say *precisely the opposite thing* about the relative purity of men's and women's love. Some critics interpret the words "thy love" and "my love" in line 25 to mean, not that the woman's less pure love will become the medium in which the speaker's love can take shape, but that the speaker himself—his lady's "love" in the sense of her beloved—will become the medium for *her* more perfect love to take shape in.

However one interprets this poem, there's a complex, sexual image at its heart, in which one love penetrates and gives form

to another. As is [so often the case in Donne](#), that passion gets aligned with the divine and the angelic; spirituality and sexuality harmonize here.

As in much of Donne's love poetry, it wouldn't be unreasonable to interpret this speaker as Donne himself, a man whose passions and intellect were equally powerful and dazzling.



SETTING

There's no clear setting in the poem; the action all takes place in the speaker's mind, heart, and imagination. But the contents of that mind, heart, and imagination all suggest that the poem is set in Donne's own time and place: 17th-century England. Through [allusions](#) to Renaissance theology (such as the belief that angels became visible by assuming bodies made of condensed air), merchant ships overloaded with wares (like the ones Donne himself sailed on in his youth), and the heavenly spheres (the crystal orbs once thought to hold the planets in their orbits), the speaker makes it clear he's a man of his times.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

John Donne (1572-1631) is remembered as one of the foremost of the "metaphysical poets"—though he never called himself one. The later writer [Samuel Johnson](#) coined the term, using it to describe a set of 17th-century English poets who wrote witty, passionate, intricate, cerebral verse about love and God. ([George Herbert](#), [Andrew Marvell](#), and [Thomas Traherne](#) were some others.)

Donne was the quintessential metaphysical poet: a master of elaborate [conceits](#) and complex sentences, and a great writer of love poems that (as this one does) mingle [images of holiness with cheeky puns](#). But during his lifetime, he was mostly a poet in private. In public life, he was an important clergyman, rising to become Dean of St. Paul's Cathedral in London.

Donne's mixture of wit, passion, and mysticism fell out of literary favor after his 17th-century heyday. For instance, when Johnson (a leading figure of the 18th-century Enlightenment) coined the term "metaphysical poet," he did not mean it as a compliment; Johnson saw Donne and his contemporaries as obscure and irrational. But 19th-century Romantic poets like [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#) were stirred by Donne's mixture of philosophy and emotion, and their enthusiasm slowly resurrected Donne's reputation. Donne is now remembered as one of the most powerful and influential of poets, and he's inspired later writers from [T. S. Eliot](#) to [A. S. Byatt](#).

Like the vast majority of Donne's poetry, "Air and Angels" didn't appear in print until several years after his death; his collection *Poems* was posthumously published in 1633.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In his youth, John Donne was a notorious ladies' man with plenty of experience both [breaking hearts](#) and [having his heart broken](#). His sometimes foolhardy decision-making around women came to a head in an oddly touching way: when he fell deeply in love with Anne More, an important official's daughter, he eloped with her without getting her family's permission. This romantic leap of faith backfired on him when his wife's angry father had him thrown in prison.

While Donne was eventually reconciled with his father-in-law, this was a rocky beginning to a marriage that would see many difficulties. The Donnes lived in relative poverty for most of their relationship. They had many children, and both of them suffered from various illnesses. In order to stay financially afloat, Donne was often forced to be literally afloat: he sailed on endless business trips all over Europe, and was often away from home for long stretches of time. His passionate love poems often tell the story of [tearful farewells](#).

It was while Donne was away on one of these many business trips that tragedy struck: Anne Donne died giving birth to a stillborn child in 1617. The heartbroken Donne turned to his religious faith for consolation—and to support his surviving children. Under the patronage of King James I, he became a prominent and successful Anglican clergyman, the Dean of St. Paul's Cathedral in London. In that capacity, he wrote devotional verse [every bit as passionate](#) as his love poetry.

- [Donne's Legacy](#) — Read a review of a recent Donne biography that discusses his enduring influence. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2022/apr/10/super-infinite-the-transformations-of-john-donne-review-masterly-study>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER JOHN DONNE POEMS

- [A Hymn to God the Father](#)
- [A Valediction: Forbidding Mourning](#)
- [A Valediction: Of Weeping](#)
- [Elegy V: His Picture](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 10: Death, be not proud](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 14: Batter my heart, three-person'd God](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 1: Thou hast made me, and shall thy work decay?](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 6: This is my play's last scene](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 7: At the round earth's imagined corners](#)
- [Hymn to God My God, in My Sickness](#)
- [No Man Is an Island](#)
- [Song: Go and catch a falling star](#)
- [The Apparition](#)
- [The Canonization](#)
- [The Flea](#)
- [The Good-Morrow](#)
- [The Relic](#)
- [The Sun Rising](#)
- [The Triple Fool](#)
- [To His Mistress Going to Bed](#)



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (<https://youtu.be/wCcmwzCRa9s?si=vkWe-GgpcYFfCpow>)
- [A Portrait of Donne](#) — See a famous portrait of Donne in which he poses as the ideal Renaissance lover. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/portrait/mw111844/John-Donne>)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about Donne's life and work via the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/john-donne>)



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